

THE LIVING CHEST



AUGUST 14, 2026

I had always wondered why fantasy treasure caves were called dungeons. Dungeons were prisons; treasure belonged in vaults.



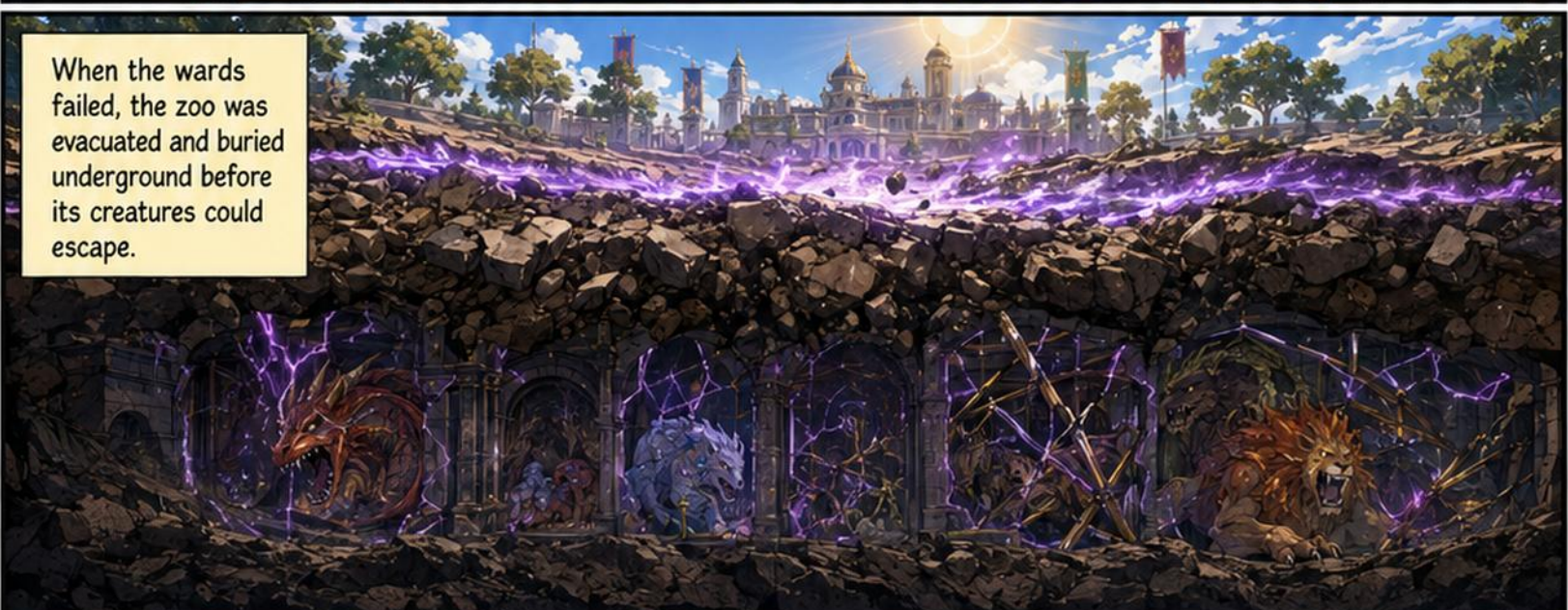
So my Lucid Light built a history that made the monsters and money belong together.



The dungeon had once been a public monster zoo, protected by magical containment wards.



When the wards failed, the zoo was evacuated and buried underground before its creatures could escape.



The zoo's owners had fled too quickly to recover that day's earnings.



Because the lost gold was insured, the insurance company had already paid for it.



A bald executive with a gray beard hired me to retrieve the company's money.



I agreed—but I had no intention of fighting blindly through an underground zoo.



At the ruined site, I opened
a passage into the buried attraction.



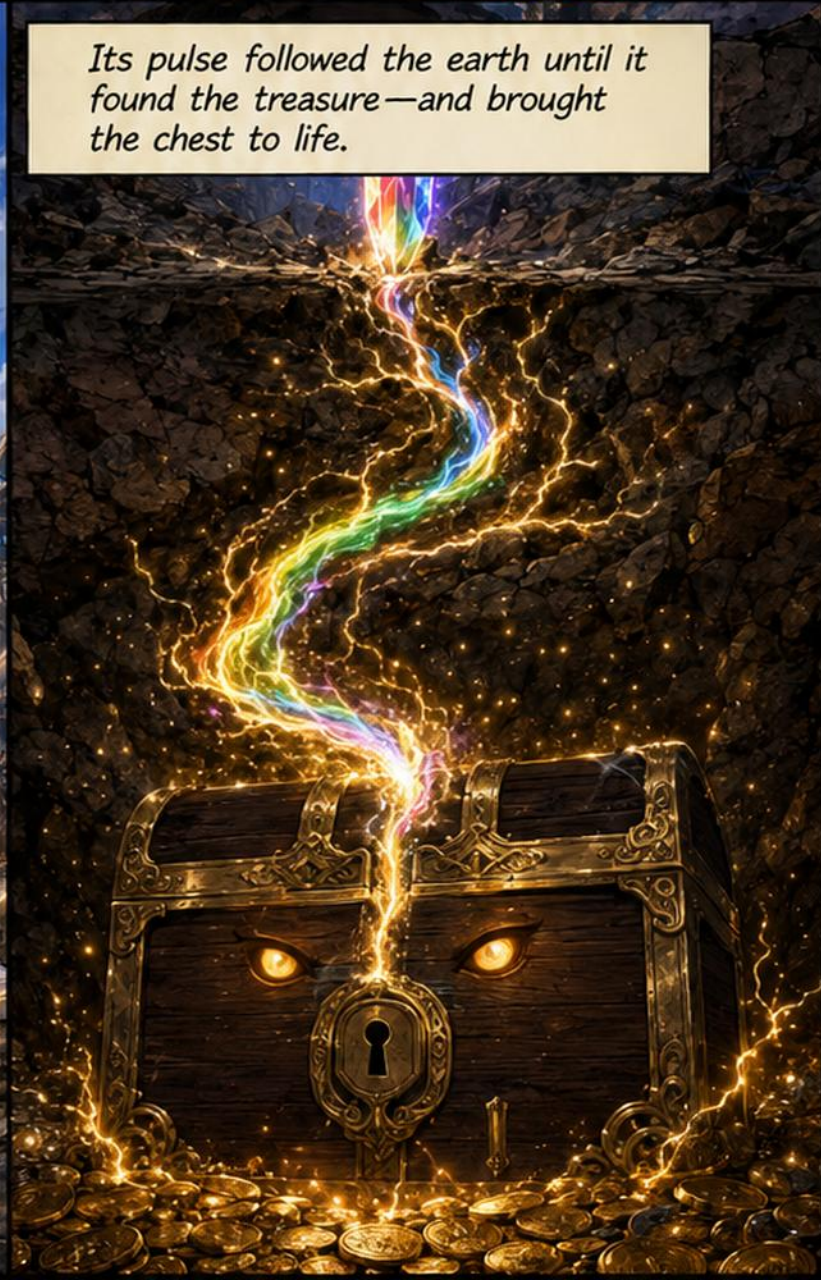
The darkness might contain any number
of surviving monsters, so I chose a
safer search.



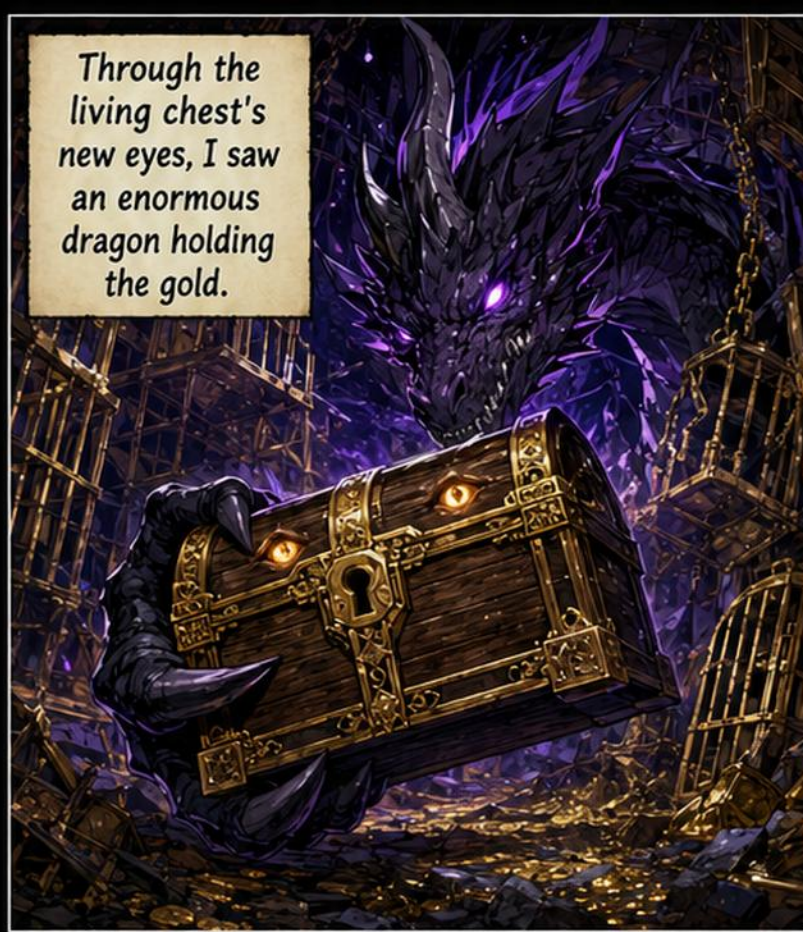
I drove Silonis, the Rainbow Crystal
Sword of Life, into the ground.



Its pulse followed the earth until it
found the treasure—and brought
the chest to life.



Through the living chest's new eyes, I saw an enormous dragon holding the gold.



The dragon immediately realized that its treasure had awakened.



Worse, the life pulse had alerted a mole monster beneath my feet.



I had to move the chest before the dragon reacted—and escape before the mole reached me.



Then I remembered
that my life energy
could fuse me with
another living thing.



The chest was alive now,
so distance no longer
had to matter.



I fused with it and tore
the treasure instantly
out of the dragon's grasp.



In one transformation,
I became a man of flesh,
polished wood, and gold.



The missing treasure enraged the dragon, and the mole monster was almost upon me.



I backdashed away from the entrance with a burst of Lucid Light.



Then I sealed the tunnel with a portal that led nowhere.



Anything entering it returned to the same side, forever unable to cross.



Once I was safe,
I released the fusion
and separated from
the treasure.



The chest returned intact,
filled with the monster zoo's
long-buried earnings.



I delivered the gold
to the insurance company
without fighting either
monster.



The dungeon made
sense—and so did
the way I conquered it.

